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A FIELD GUIDE FROM PERSEVERANT DIGITAL

The Local Map Pack Playbook

How a high-value service business earns a place in Google's map pack, turns that visibility into booked consultations, and stops paying for every click.

THE SHORT ANSWER · 60 WORDS

REVIEWED OCTOBER 15, 2026

To compete in Google's map pack, make your Business Profile the most complete and relevant match for each service you sell, earn a steady flow of honest reviews, and support it with a website that has a real page for each service and town. Google ranks local results on relevance, distance and prominence, and nobody can pay for local rank.

How does Google decide who shows up in the map pack?

Google ranks local results mainly on relevance, distance and prominence, and says there is no way to pay for a better local ranking (Google Business Profile Help). Fundamentals win.

- **Relevance**: how well your profile and site match the search. A category naming the exact service beats a broad one.
- **Distance**: how far you are from the searcher. You win by being strong enough to rank farther out.
- **Prominence**: how well known you are, from reviews, links, mentions and site strength.

This is Search Essence Optimization. People search to understand you, not just find you. Make the answer to “can I trust them?” clear, so prospect and business meet in the middle.

What this looks like for your business

Whatever you sell, the pattern is the same. Pick the most specific category, list only the area you truly serve, and show proof a careful buyer can check. The rest of this playbook works for any high-value local service.

Why are we ranking but not getting calls?

Usually one of four patterns:

- **Wrong searches.** Ranking for your own name or research terms produces few calls.
- **Small circle.** Map rank changes block by block. You may top the pack near your office and vanish two miles away.
- **Weak answer.** Few reviews, no photos or a slow mobile site loses to a more trustworthy competitor one spot lower.
- **AI summaries.** Pew Research Center found Google users clicked a traditional result on 8% of visits when an AI summary appeared, versus 15% without (July 22, 2025). Seer Interactive, an agency, found brands cited in an AI Overview earned 35% more organic clicks (November 4, 2025). Pages must rank and be quotable.

Step 1: Complete your Google Business Profile

Your profile is the map pack listing. Finish this list, then review it quarterly.

- [ ] Choose the most specific **primary category** for your main service.
- [ ] Add **secondary categories** only for services you actually sell.
- [ ] Use your real business name, with no added keywords or towns.
- [ ] Show your address, or hide it and set **service areas** to the region you truly serve.
- [ ] Add every **service** with a short, plain description.
- [ ] Set regular and holiday **hours**.
- [ ] Write a plain **description**: who you serve, what you do, where.
- [ ] Replace stock images with real **photos**.
- [ ] Add a **UTM-tagged website link** (`?utm_source=google&utm_medium=organic&utm_campaign=gbp`). If you use call tracking, make the tracking number primary and your main number additional.

- [ ] Publish a **post** at least twice a month.

Examples. Confirm category names in your profile editor.

Profile field	Example
Primary category	“Roofing contractor” rather than “Contractor”; “Estate planning attorney” rather than “Law firm”
Services	A named consultation, an inspection or an assessment
Photos	The team, the office or vehicles, finished work where appropriate
Posts	A recent project, a seasonal reminder, a short answer to a common question

Step 2: Build a review system you can defend

Reviews are the part of prominence you control most. BrightLocal’s 2026 vendor survey of 1,002 US adults found 47% won’t use a business with fewer than 20 reviews (February 11, 2026). Pass 20, then match the count and recency of the top three in your pack.

Keep it honest. The FTC’s review rule, finalized August 2024, bans fake or AI-generated reviews, buying reviews, incentives tied to positive sentiment, undisclosed insider reviews and suppression (Morgan Lewis, August 26, 2024).

- [ ] Ask **every** client at a set moment. No gating unhappy ones to a private form.
- [ ] Send a direct link by text or email, with consent, within a day of that moment.
- [ ] Never reward a positive review, and don’t let staff or family review without disclosure.
- [ ] Reply to **every** review within a few days, written fresh. BrightLocal found 50% are put off by templated replies.
- [ ] Answer criticism calmly, once, offline if possible.

Ask when the work is finished and the client sees the result. In replies, never share private details about the client or their job.

Fill in your weekly routine:

Item	Your answer
The moment we ask	
Who sends requests and who replies	
Reviews this month / target	
Our count vs top competitor	

This is not legal advice; check your licensing board's rules too.

Step 3: Build pages for each service, town and person

Your profile ranks better when your website backs it up: one page per core service, a town page only where you have something real to say, and a bio for each person prospects search by name. Pages that just swap town names help no one.

Local proof means work handled there, local rules or permits, drive time, a team member who lives nearby and questions people in that area actually ask.

Service	Town	Real local detail	Local proof	Common local question	Build?

Build a bio for each person clients work with, with credentials and licenses stated factually.

Build only pages where you can fill every column. Each bio needs the licensed name, a real photo, the services that person handles and Person schema.

Make every page quotable: a direct two-sentence answer up top, question headings, a short FAQ. Keep content in plain HTML; Vercel found none of the major AI crawlers, including GPTBot and ClaudeBot, render JavaScript (December 17, 2024).

Step 4: Run the 15-minute technical health check

Content can't rank on a site Google can't read.

- [ ] Search `site:yourdomain.com`. The count should roughly match your real pages.
- [ ] Check why pages aren't indexed in Search Console's **Pages** report.
- [ ] Run your home page and top service page through **PageSpeed Insights** on mobile.
- [ ] Check that your top ten pages each have a unique **title tag** naming the service and place, and one H1.
- [ ] Test **schema** with Google's Rich Results Test. Name, address, phone and hours should match the profile.
- [ ] Confirm `robots.txt` doesn't block search or AI crawlers by accident.

Every failure goes on your fix list.

Step 5: Measure calls and booked consultations, not rankings

Rankings are a means; booked appointments are the result.

Metric	Where to find it	This month	Last month
Profile calls and direction requests	Business Profile performance		
Website clicks from profile	Analytics, filtered by your UTM		
Organic clicks and top queries	Search Console		
Form fills and calls from organic	Analytics and call tracking		
Appointments booked from search	Your CRM or calendar		

Cost per booked appointment from SEO = monthly SEO spend ÷ appointments booked from search and maps.

Example numbers, not benchmarks: $3,000 a month producing 15 booked appointments is $200 each. Compare that with bought leads on the same basis. Bought leads start fast and stop when you stop paying; SEO starts slower and keeps working. Many owners do both.

Where do most owners get stuck?

> **Seeing the whole map.** One search from your desk shows one point. Knowing your rank across your service area takes map-grid data collected repeatedly over time.

> **Content and links at scale.** Dozens of substantive, compliant pages plus mentions from local press and associations take steady time most owners don't have.

> **Technical fixes on your CMS.** Knowing a page is not indexed is different from fixing the template, redirect or plugin that caused it. That work often needs a developer.

If you want a second set of eyes on any of these, book the 25-minute exploration call with the short form at the end of this guide.

Sources

- Google Business Profile Help, "Tips to improve your local ranking on Google," accessed October 15, 2026. link
- Pew Research Center, "Google users are less likely to click on links when an AI summary appears in the results," July 22, 2025. link
- Seer Interactive (agency study), "AIO impact on Google CTR: September 2025 update," November 4, 2025. link
- BrightLocal (vendor survey), "Local Consumer Review Survey 2026," February 11, 2026. link
- Morgan Lewis, "FTC issues final rule on consumer reviews and testimonials," August 26, 2024. link
- Vercel, "The rise of the AI crawler," December 17, 2024. link

Want a second set of eyes on what you found?

Book a free 25-minute exploration call. We will look at your answers with you, name the first fixes in order, and tell you honestly if we are not the right fit.

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